

DE-ESCALATION TRAINING

Purpose: To equip volunteers to recognize early signs of conflict or emotional distress and respond in ways that restore calm, maintain safety, and protect relationships.

WHEN DE-ESCALATION MAY BE NEEDED

Our role as Community Camp Leaders is to help foster a safe atmosphere where students are connected to the person of Jesus and with one another. De-escalation techniques should be used whenever a student:

- Is **visibly upset, angry, or anxious** (crying, yelling, pacing, withdrawn)
 - **Argues** with another camper or a leader
 - **Refuses to participate** or follow instructions
 - Is **overwhelmed** (emotionally, socially, or spiritually)
 - Displays **attention-seeking or disruptive behavior**
 - Is **triggered** by correction or discipline
 - Appears to be **isolating** or shutting down
 - There's a **misunderstanding or conflict** between students or volunteers
 - A **safety concern** is developing but hasn't yet escalated (e.g., teasing, pushing, heated conversation)
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BEST PRACTICES FOR HANDLING THESE SITUATIONS

1. Stay Calm and Grounded

- Keep your **tone low and slow** — your calm helps them regulate.
- **Don't match their energy** — lower yours to lower theirs.
- **Take a deep breath** before responding.

2. Create Space and Safety

- **Give physical space** (stand at an angle, not directly in front).
- **Avoid touching** the student when they're upset.
- **Remove the audience** if possible — pull them aside to a less crowded, loud, or stimulating environment.

3. Listen Before You Speak

- Let them talk without interruption.
- Use **active listening**: Have genuine desire to understand what the student is experiencing. "It sounds like you're frustrated because..."
- **Validate feelings** without excusing behavior:
"I can see that you're upset. It's okay to feel that way, but it's not okay to yell."

4. Identify the Underlying Need

Ask yourself: *Is this about control, attention, fear, or frustration?*

Respond to the need, not just the behavior.

Examples:

- If they feel unheard → listen.
- If they need control → offer choices.
- If they're embarrassed → move conversation to a less crowded area.

5. Offer Simple Choices and Solutions

- Give **two clear options**:
"You can take a break in the cabin, or we can walk and talk for a minute."
- Keep directions short and calm.
- Focus on what **can** happen, not what **can't**:
"You can rejoin when you're ready," instead of "You can't come back until you stop."

6. Use Non-Threatening Language

Avoid:

- "Calm down."
- "You're overreacting."
- "You need to stop."

Instead say:

- "Let's take a minute to breathe."
- "I want to understand what's going on."
- "I'm here to help, not to argue."

7. Know When to Get Help

- If a student **refuses to de-escalate, walks away, or threatens harm**, immediately contact Carson Clark or Brigette Filbrun, who can bring in the Safety team if needed.
- **Never handle a physical confrontation alone.**
- Always **document and report** any major incident after it's resolved.

8. After the Situation

- **Debrief privately** with the student: "What could we do differently next time?"
 - **Affirm reconciliation** and remind them they're cared for.
 - **Inform leadership** so follow-up can happen if needed.
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QUICK "[DE-ESCALATION DO'S AND DON'TS](#)"

Do:

- Stay calm
- Listen actively
- Speak softly and slowly
- Keep posture open and relaxed
- Offer choices
- Call for support early

Don't:

- Yell, argue, or threaten
- Corner or crowd them
- Take it personally
- Make promises you can't keep
- Ignore warning signs